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BRIEFING NOTE

Supporting Afghan Women's Engagement Strategies Recommendations



Female staff meet at Malalai Maternity Hospital in Kabul (Credit: Elise Blanchard)

Key messages

- **Afghan women continue to negotiate space for themselves within Taliban rule.** Despite extreme restrictions, Afghan women employ direct, indirect, and digital engagement strategies to sustain their presence in public life. Their negotiations are often informal, high-risk, and fragile, but they remain one of the few viable ways to sustain women's participation in business, healthcare, and service delivery.
- **Third-party facilitators play a crucial role in enabling women's engagement.** Afghan and international organisations help women navigate Taliban bureaucracy, create safe spaces for dialogue, and provide training on negotiation tactics. These intermediaries help mitigate risks and expand opportunities for women's engagement in a highly constrained environment.
- **International support should be discreet, flexible, and aligned with Afghan women's own strategies.** Rigid donor expectations or public visibility can increase risks for Afghan women. Instead, funding should be as adaptable as possible, responsive to shifting Taliban policies, and designed to reinforce Afghan strategies.
- **Sustaining women's engagement today can help support future inclusion.** While the current political environment is deeply restrictive, Afghan women's negotiations with the Taliban are preserving essential spaces for public participation. Investing in their strategies now can help ensure they have a foundation to build on when new opportunities for women's inclusion emerge.

Introduction

The systematic exclusion of Afghan women from public life under Taliban rule presents profound challenges to rights, humanitarian access, service delivery and governance in Afghanistan. Despite increasingly restrictive policies, negotiate for space within Taliban governance structures. They do this through complex, multi-layered strategies of direct and indirect engagement with the authorities. These negotiations are high-risk, ad hoc, and demand flexibility and creativity. Nevertheless, they are among the few available and effective pathways for sustaining women's public roles.

The Centre on Armed Groups has conducted extensive research with Afghan women, Afghan officials, and other key informants on how Afghan women negotiate with the Taliban for public inclusion and under what conditions these negotiations yield tangible gains. Our research concluded that international donors can play a critical role in strengthening locally driven dialogue processes that enhance women's engagement strategies. International funding in itself often created spaces for women through supporting areas where it is acceptable for women to engage (e.g., service delivery, livelihoods, support to the private sector).

Yet much more can be done to further women's own capacity to engage and their influence. This briefing note outlines concrete recommendations for donors, UN agencies, and international NGOs to strengthen women's dialogue, enhance their bargaining power, and ensure their inclusion in Afghanistan's evolving governance structures

The role of third-party support in women's dialogue

Our research shows that third-party organisations play a critical role in enabling women's engagement strategies. These organisations provide services that help address women's needs, fill gaps, reduce risk and expand access in several key ways:

Information sharing

Women engaging with the Taliban operate in a low-information, unstable environment where rules are inconsistently enforced. Third-party actors help mitigate uncertainty by disseminating information on Taliban rulings, bureaucratic procedures, and negotiation strategies that enable women to triangulate and analyse pertinent information, which allows them to navigate restrictions more effectively.

Safe spaces for engagement

Many Afghan organisations provide private office spaces where women's groups can safely convene, hold meetings, and engage in professional activities while adhering to Taliban segregation policies. Some international actors may also be able to support neutral venues for women's dialogue with each other as well as with authorities or other relevant actors.

Dialogue training and capacity building

Women specifically requested more structured training on negotiation and training on how to advocate for their rights within Sharia frameworks accepted by the Taliban. Some of this is already happening, but there is appetite for much more.

Public convening and dialogue mechanisms

Some Afghan organisations facilitate consultative dialogues with Taliban officials at local and provincial levels, enabling communities to voice grievances and seek redress through structured town halls and similar meetings. Afghan organisations convening these meetings can help ensure that they comprise women from different sectors (business, healthcare, education, and humanitarian work) to bring distinct perspectives to the table.

Collective bargaining and network mobilisation

Women's organisations increasingly rely on coalition-building strategies to engage with Taliban ministries and directorates, advocating for policy exemptions or negotiating operational gui-

lines for women's participation in education, business, and healthcare. Certain collectives and business associations are already doing this, but may be able to expand or strengthen their work with further support.

Sectoral shifts and adaptations

Women's engagement in livelihoods, business, and healthcare sectors remain among the few relatively accepted avenues for public participation. In particular, our research observed a trend of more women transitioning to the private sector, and women themselves requested donor support to do this.

Recommendations

Do no harm

Not all women can or should directly engage with the authorities. The research found that engagement was not desirable or possible for some women. Donors should not expect or pressure Afghan women to engage. Rather they should find ways of tailoring their support to the different strategies women have adopted, based on their own assessments of the risks and opportunities.

Expand support to third-party and other facilitators

Given the risks women face, third-party facilitation is essential for ensuring safety and increasing negotiation leverage. Provide logistical and financial support to Afghan-led dialogue forums that connect women's organisations with one another, and with Taliban authorities. This could include support to:

- Expand secure convening spaces where Afghan women can meet, strategise, and coordinate engagement with Taliban officials.
- Provide technical and financial support for third-party mediators, including religious scholars, former Republic officials, and other male allies who serve as interlocutors.

Be as flexible as possible

Adaptive funding modalities are critical. This could include adaptations to current funding modalities or the creation of small, rapid-response funding pools to enable local organisations to shift strategies as new Taliban policies emerge.

Minimise risk

Minimise donor visibility requirements and any public discussion of this work to prevent Taliban backlash against internationally supported women's initiatives. Find discreet ways to communicate the success of these efforts and advocate for continued donor support.

Follow Afghan women's leadership in negotiations

Consult with a diverse array of Afghan women and women-led organisations in Afghanistan across sectors. These consultations should inform donor priorities, positioning and modalities. Avoid imposing external models, buzzwords or expectations that do not align with Afghan women's priorities, constraints or local realities.

Conclusion

Afghan women's ongoing negotiations with the Taliban demonstrate agency in an increasingly constrained environment. The role of international donors and actors should be to enable Afghan women to define their own strategies for manoeuvring within Taliban rule. With the right strategies, international actors can play a crucial role in preserving Afghan women's public roles, even under the most restrictive conditions. Supporting these adaptive engagement strategies is not just about sustaining women's participation today but about laying the groundwork for future openings for women's public inclusion in Afghanistan, as and when they appear.

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